

The Detachable Telos

Two extensions to constitutive rhetoric, read through Alberta 2026.

Working draft, subject to revision.

Prospective venue: NCA Political Communication Division (2027 cycle). Marked prospective, not committed.

Charland's 1987 model assumes that when rhetoric constitutes a people it hands them a telos that follows from their identity. Alberta's 2026 referendum is a case where the identity holds and the telos does not, and where a prior people blocks the ground the appeal claims. Those two facts mark two extensions the model needs.

The apparatus, in brief

Constitutive rhetoric calls a people into being and embeds three effects: a transhistorical identity, a collective agency, and a telos presented as the people's completion.¹ Québec is the canonical fit. A thick ethnos, a forward telos to sovereignty, and a 1995 vote lost by one point.² The model treats identity and telos as fused. The Alberta case is where that fusion comes apart.

Extension one: the telos is detachable

Alberta's constitutive appeal is built from grievance rather than ethnos, the province being younger than the treaties that cross it. The rhetoric records the detachment in its own instruments. The governing act is titled Alberta Sovereignty within a United Canada, and the October 19 ballot asks only whether to begin a legal process toward a future, non-binding referendum.³ Polling shows the same gap in the population: about 60 percent would vote No on the official question while still holding the Alberta-grievance identity, and roughly two-thirds choose to stay on a plain leave-or-remain framing.⁴ A constituted identity can be real while its telos is declined. The model should treat the telos as a separable component whose adhesion depends on the thickness of the substrate.

Extension two: the prior-people collision

Constitutive rhetoric assumes open ground. Treaties 6, 7, and 8 predate the 1905 province and constitute a people already.⁵ On May 13, 2026 the Court of King's Bench quashed the separation petition for the Crown's failure to consult First Nations whose Treaty rights separation would affect.⁶ The 1998 Secession Reference set the frame: no unilateral exit, and negotiation owed on a clear result.⁷ Québec's 1995 Cree counter-referendum, 96.3 percent to remain, was the same collision a decade earlier.⁸ The model needs a term for the case where the ground is already constituted under law, because there the appeal meets a limit argument cannot move.

Why Alberta is the useful case

Québec shows the model working. Alberta shows its seams, because the substrate is thin enough to separate identity from telos and the treaty claim is live enough to reach a courtroom in the same year as the vote. The contribution is small and specific: two variables, detachability and the prior claim, that a forward-pointing 1987 account left fixed.

Notes

- Charland (1987); McGee (1975).
- Élections Québec, 1995 results.
- Alberta Sovereignty within a United Canada Act; CBC, Oct. 19 question wording.
- Angus Reid Institute, 2026.
- Numbered Treaties 6–8.
- Athabasca Chipewyan First Nation v Alberta (CEO), King's Bench, May 13, 2026.
- Reference re Secession of Quebec \[1998\].
- Cree counter-referendum, 1995.

Citations and links in the Literature Review.